

Dear Daughter,

Others see you throwing a teenage tantrum.
I see you standing your ground.

They see you as stubborn, not listening to their advice.

I see you setting boundaries for yourself.

Some see you changing your mind all the time.

I see a girl listening to her heart all the time.

They see you being friendly with boys.

I see you breaking their rules and judgements.

Some see you rebelling.

I see a girl expressing herself.

I see you, my daughter

16 and already owning your story
And I couldn't be more proud.

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EATING RESET

Restaurateur Karan Gokani on how GLP-1 is shaping menus, with smaller portions and more protein **P2**

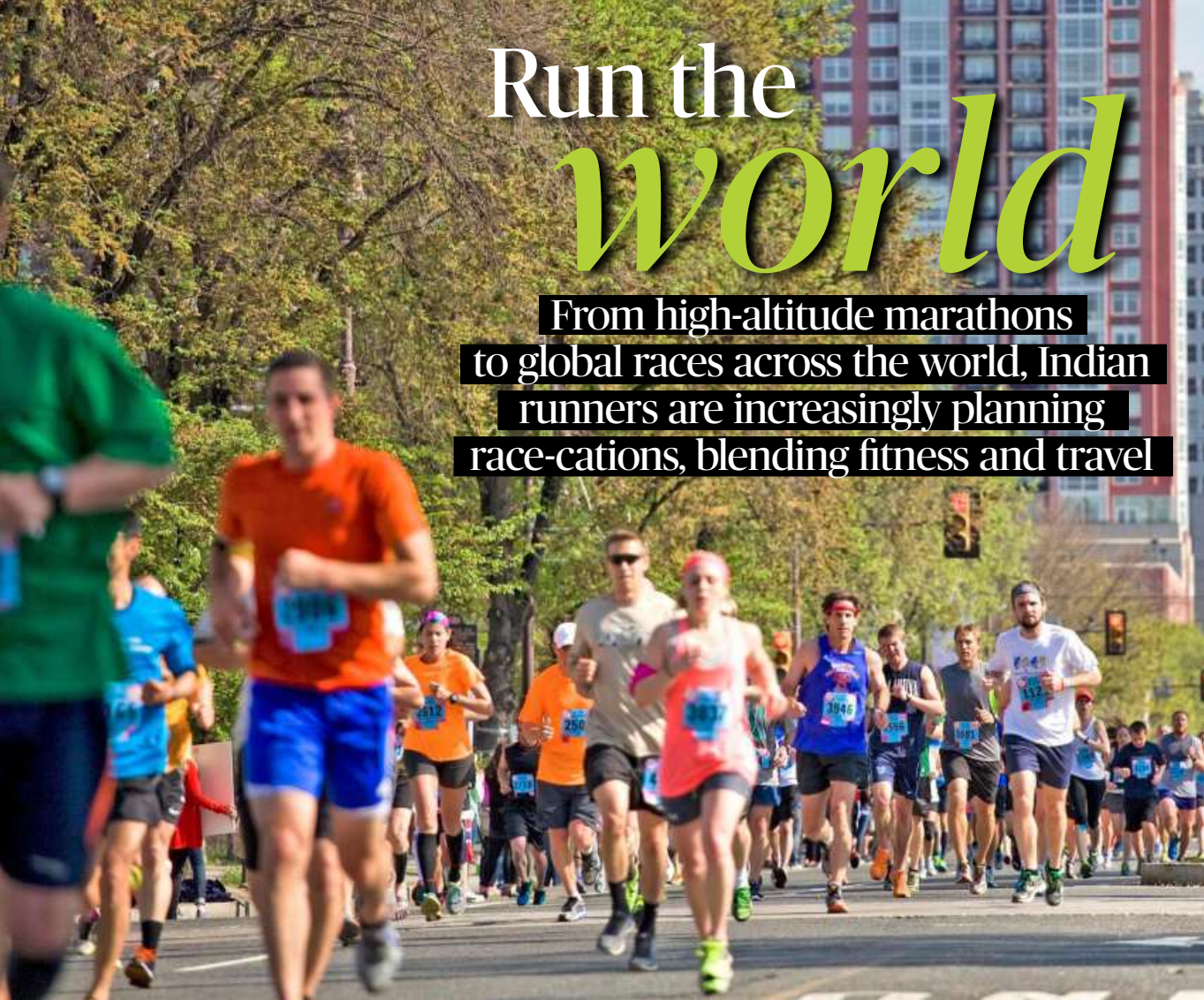


PHOTO: PHILADELPHIA CONVENTION AND VISITORS BUREAU

Run the world

From high-altitude marathons to global races across the world, Indian runners are increasingly planning race-cations, blending fitness and travel

Naina Rajpaal

At 5 am, long before Bengaluru's traffic thickens and cafes pull up their shutters, Sunil Lade is already several kilometres into his run.

An ad-film producer, he spends most days thinking in frames, shots, and deadlines. Now he is training for another deadline: the London Marathon on April 26, after which he will prepare for the Chicago Marathon on October 11. His upcoming trip is a solo vacation, for some much-needed me-time. While the London marathon is the prime reason he is travelling, he plans to explore the Scottish Highlands for five days.

Sunil is part of a growing tribe of Indian runners planning holidays around races, a trend now referred to as race-cations. Instead of just seeing the tourist sights, they experience countries differently by running through local neighbourhoods while being cheered on by strangers. "I've been to cities for work and for travel," says Sunil. "But what you see when you're running is totally different. You notice

details you'd never catch in a car or train."

The runner-tourist Social media influencer and long-distance runner Sahirah Oshidar, from Bengaluru, believes travelling specifically for fitness is the next big thing. "Why simply travel, when you can work on your fitness and achieve new milestones on the same vacation?" she says. Sahirah is new to the international running scene with the Bangkok Marathon on November 16 last year being her first. She describes the energy as electric. This year, she is eyeing Portugal (October 2-3, 2026) and Abu Dhabi (December 12, 2026).

Accor, a multinational hospitality company, in partnership with travel trend forecasting agency Globetrender, published a study in January 2026 by surveying 4,300 travellers across countries, including India, the UK and the US. According to their report, the 'endorphin economy' is on the rise and 89% of travellers surveyed said live events like marathons are worth travelling for.

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pick of the week



Jewels on
Meenu Subbiah Diamonds unveils Vilasam, a Chettinad-inspired bridal collection that redefines tradition with lightweight designs. Crafted in 22-karat gold with Burmese rubies and Colombian emeralds, the range includes bangles, oddiyanams, and necklaces featuring signature peacock motifs. On view at the T Nagar showroom as part of the Thirumana Thiruvizha exhibit until May 15, 11am to 8pm. Prices start at ₹4 lakh.



Know your city
Marking World Art Deco Month, Capturing Cities: Art Deco Edition, brings a mix of walking and sketching capturing the charm of Gandhi Nagar, Adyar on April 26, from 4.30pm to 7.30 pm. This session begins with a guided neighbourhood walk to discover vintage Art Deco bungalows followed by a sketching session at Backyard, Adyar. The event is hosted by artists Abhilaasha and Architha. Priced ₹1,000, all materials included. To register call, 9884012847



Summer dressing
Amrchi by designers Amit Vijaya and Richard Pandav, presents its Spring Summer 2026 collection, Of Light & Shadow. Inspired by contrasts of light and dark, the collection features tops, dresses, and trousers. Crafted with traditional techniques like shibori on natural fabrics, the pieces balance fluid and structured forms. The colour palette includes black and white, accented with acid colours. On from April 30 to May 31, 11pm to 7.30pm at Collage, Rutland Gate.



Mascot call
The Badminton Association of India has launched its first nationwide mascot design contest for the BWF World Championships 2026, inviting fans, artists, and creators to contribute to the event's identity. Open till May 10, the winner will receive ₹25,000 and VIP tickets to the semi-finals or finals. Entries will be judged on creativity, originality, thematic relevance, and overall visual appeal. For details log in to badmintonindia.org

Ozempic-style weight-loss drugs are reshaping how people eat – from smaller portions to protein-led menus

Karan Gokani

A few weeks ago, a regular at one of my restaurants ordered her usual lunch, but barely touched it. Before leaving, she confided that she'd been on a new weight-loss "programme" since spring and was still learning her new appetite, but truly missed our food. Or the idea of it, at least.

The conversation touched on something I've been discussing internally with my leadership team for months. The GLP-1 effect on eating is no longer a rumour, it's all around us.

Supermarket shelves in London have already adapted. M&S has rolled out a "Nutrient Dense" range designed around high-protein, high-fibre meals in smaller portions. Morrisons has "Small & Balanced," the UK's first supermarket range explicitly labelled GLP-1-friendly. India meanwhile is embracing protein lassi, kulfi and even bhel bars.

Fast food has been on the uptake too. Shake Shack in the US launched a "Good Fit Menu" at the end of last year featuring lettuce-wrapped burgers, higher-protein options, explicitly stickered as GLP-1-friendly. Chipotle introduced a High Protein Menu in December, and Starbucks has been pushing protein lattes and cold foams.

The writing is on the walls. It's time for the rest of us to catch up. A UCL study put the number of UK adults on Wegovy or Mounjaro at 1.6 million in the year to early 2025, with a further 3.3 million interested in starting.



India is set to become the world's largest producer of affordable GLP-1s. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

AT THE TABLE

Is your dinner shrinking?

In the US, over fifteen million people are now on GLP-1s. Then there is India. On March 20 this year, the Indian patent protecting Novo Nordisk's semaglutide expired, and within days dozens of generics had landed from Sun Pharma, Dr Reddy's, Zydus, Lupin and others. At prices as low as ₹900 a month, a fraction of the original. India is set to become the world's largest producer of affordable GLP-1s.

Sitting in London and watching this unfold in the country I grew up in, I find myself unusually interested in what happens next. A dining culture built on abundance, feeding, and festivity about to meet a drug that could change everything.

The easy assumption is that restaurants lose. The reality is

less straightforward and for innovative restaurateurs, potentially the opposite.

Diners on GLP-1s aren't losing their love of food, they're just eating less of it. And the newer wave of users is doing so deliberately, taking lower carefully titrated doses, paired with lifestyle changes rather than the appetite-obliterating protocols of the early days.

However, there seems to be an impact on the palate in the process. Many report that their taste buds get fussier. The salt-fat-sugar loop that powers so much of the processed and ultra-processed food economy stops working on them. What still lands though, are balanced meals providing depth, flavour and real ingredients. Which is to say, the restaurants most exposed to GLP-1s are the ones trading on

volume and grease. The ones putting thought into ingredient quality and balanced menus may actually gain because many purse strings may have gotten looser.

Users of weight loss drugs still want the company, the room, the novelty, and the notion of being looked after. Just like our regulars. They're simply ordering differently.

Which means restaurateurs, including me, need to approach this with the same creativity we once brought to gluten-free, vegan, and allergen diners. Half portions of popular dishes, clearly marked and fairly priced. Macros visible enough that a GLP-1 diner doesn't have to interrogate the waiter. A protein and ingredient-led section that puts grilled fish or chicken breast at its centre. Good for the GLP-1 diner and no worse for anyone else. Shorter, modular tasting menus. Sharing dishes engineered so the person on the drug and the person off it can sit at the same table without either feeling out of step.

And a drinks list that takes ferments, soft drinks, and low and no-alcohol options seriously. Because one side-effect of these drugs is an almost total collapse of the urge to drink, and drinks, for most restaurants, are where the margin lives.

The bigger question is pace and scale. Fast-casual and QSR, built on the economics of one person eating one big plate, will feel it first and hardest. Fine dining is also exposed, because its core demographic overlaps heavily with the people who can afford £200 a month privately.

The casual middle will have to get more innovative on dishes, more flexible on portions, and more thoughtful about optics.

Chefs and restaurants have been in a quiet kind of denial about all this. But what used to turn up anecdotally at one table in fifty now turns up at one in ten, and once Indian generics reach the disposable-income class across large cities, that curve will steepen exponentially. The restaurants that adapt early will be the ones still full in five years.

And so they should be. Hospitality, at its best, is the art of making everyone at the table feel welcome. A guest who needs less food is no less of a guest.

Karan Gokani is a London-based chef and restaurateur who spends his time cooking, travelling and exploring what the world is eating. He loves the gym, biriyani and his frying pan. Not necessarily in that order.



S. Poorvaja
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In Ahmedabad, on a sweltering day, I take a mango out of a bright box. The fruit looks much too smooth, almost too perfect to cut into, but I go at it crème brûlée-style, gently tapping on its chocolate-coated yellow shell, cracking it open to reveal thick, creamy ice cream.

This is Hocco's Aamchi, which went viral on Instagram last year. In Chennai, though, the ice cream was not available last summer, making us feel the FOMO. That changes this summer. While Aamchi is now available on quick commerce apps including Swiggy, Zepto and Blinkit (and selling out just as quickly), the Ahmedabad-based brand is also opening its Hocco Creameries in Chennai. Founder Ankit Chona confirms the brand will open seven outlets in the city – in Egmore, Kilpauk, Vepery, Kathipara, Alwarpet, Adyar and Sowcarpet – this summer.

At a Hocco Creamery in Ahmedabad, ahead of the Chennai launch, I explore the OG space: cheery walls, ice creams that include the classics as well as flavours like charcoal lychee and blueberry cheesecake, and a menu that has both sweet and savoury waffles.

"We are not just sending ice cream to the State, we are setting up a whole team in Tamil Nadu," Ankit says. We bring up the FOMO from last summer and Ankit is quick to clarify that the brand did not deprioritise the south. "We are expanding, with two new factories coming up which includes one in

The big SCOOP



(Clockwise from far left) Ice creams from Hocco and Huber & Holly; and Ankit Chona. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

After going viral last summer, Ahmedabad-based Hocco brings its Aamchi mango ice cream and ice cream parlours to Chennai timed to peak mango season.

Panipat, and we hope to be in all the southern states by next summer," he says.

Scoop science served
The brand's revenue, during summer (from March to June), makes up nearly 55% of their annual sales. With its expanded facilities in Ahmedabad and Panipat, the ice cream brand's production capacity will stand at nearly 3 lakh litres per day, operating at near full capacity during peak season. There are plans to increase capacity to 4.5 lakh litres per day. "What we are doing this summer is probably what we imagined we would do the entire year when we set up the first Hocco factory three years ago," he says, of how demand has steadily risen over the last three years.

At the Hocco factory in Bavla, approximately 40 kilometres from Ahmedabad Airport, the scent of milk hits you the moment you walk in. We walk through how their many ice creams are conceived (some flavours are birthed after 40 or more trials, the staff say) before the factory floor looms into view.

I watch the steady thrum of mechanisation and labour; rows of vanilla popsicles being neatly dipped into mango syrup, scoops of chocolate ice cream being placed by a whirring machine on chocolate cones and rows of workers neatly packing Aamchi into boxes. We are told the

factory churns out, nearly 10,000 Oh Cone ice creams every hour, and 12,000 Chillo cones. As we take in these numbers, we get the handed soft swirls of biscoff ice cream, straight from the production line.

After a tasting session that includes Hocco's chunky chocolate Boss Bars, and sampling a new range of tin cakes from their sister brand Huber & Holly in flavours like Dubai Chocolate Kunafa and blueberry creme, and the Jamun Spark bars, we are sworn to secrecy and given first crack at their newest launch, Leemo. Much like Aamchi, Leemo, is a creamy lemon ice cream, that comes encased in white chocolate and is shaped like a lemon.

"We experimented with a whole lot of fruits, including strawberry for winter. Lemons or a chilled glass of nimbu pani, felt comforting and nostalgic for a summer launch, much like how we wanted Aamchi to draw from the experience of eating a sweet, cold mango on a hot summer day," Ankit says.

While Leemo hit the market in Gujarat this week and will soon be available across the country, there are other big launches in the offing, betting big on familiar, comfort flavours.

The writer was at Hocco, Ahmedabad on invitation from the brand

Art on a sari

Artists and master weavers from India transform the Kanjeevaram into a canvas for the Asian Art Museum in San Francisco

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The sari – 18 feet in length – is an unstitched marvel worn by women across all walks of life, from labourers to queens," says artist and curator Vara Ramakrishnan. She recently showcased 34 saris featuring artwork by artists and master weavers for a one-day exhibition held at the Asian Art Museum, San Francisco, USA.

The theme was Journey and Exile. "The idea was to highlight the value of these pieces – not just in looking at them, but in experiencing them. We plan to auction these saris in May," says the curator.

Chennai-based artist Lakshmi Srinath's sari represents the Devadasi system. "I was given an ivory silk sari with golden checks to work on, and I dyed it with Shibori technique to resemble granite stone in a temple. The design is a deconstructed kolam, conveying a sense of incompleteness, and is strewn with jasmine flowers," she says.

Vara Ramakrishnan notes that while most artists were given silk saris, Chennai-based House of Tuhil was invited to design a thematic sari. With design inputs from Varsha Kumar and D Jayakumar, the sari, Meenakshi: Goddess of Madurai, was woven by B Srinivasan under the supervision of master weaver PL Banumurthi.

Art director and painter Thota Tharani's contribution, titled Thota: Garden, is a fabric painting on a silk sari. "Thota,"

meaning "garden," explores how memory and identity travel with us across places. The sari evokes the imagery of a portable garden, representing how we carry our roots and memories.

Designer Prabha Narasimhan created meticulous embroidery, including thread work, aari embroidery and French knots, for saris designed by artists Kanchan Chander, Seema Kohli, Shirin Nijhawan, and Vara Ramakrishnan.



This sari titled, Ganesha, is designed by Shirin Nijhawan and enhanced with embroidery by Prabha Narasimhan. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Kavitha Prasad – an artist, architect, and educator – created a painted sari. Translating her practice onto silk required rethinking her approach: understanding how fabric absorbs pigment. The result is a Kanjeevaram silk sari painted with silk dyes, gutta, and acrylics – meditative in quality and rooted in close observation of the natural world.

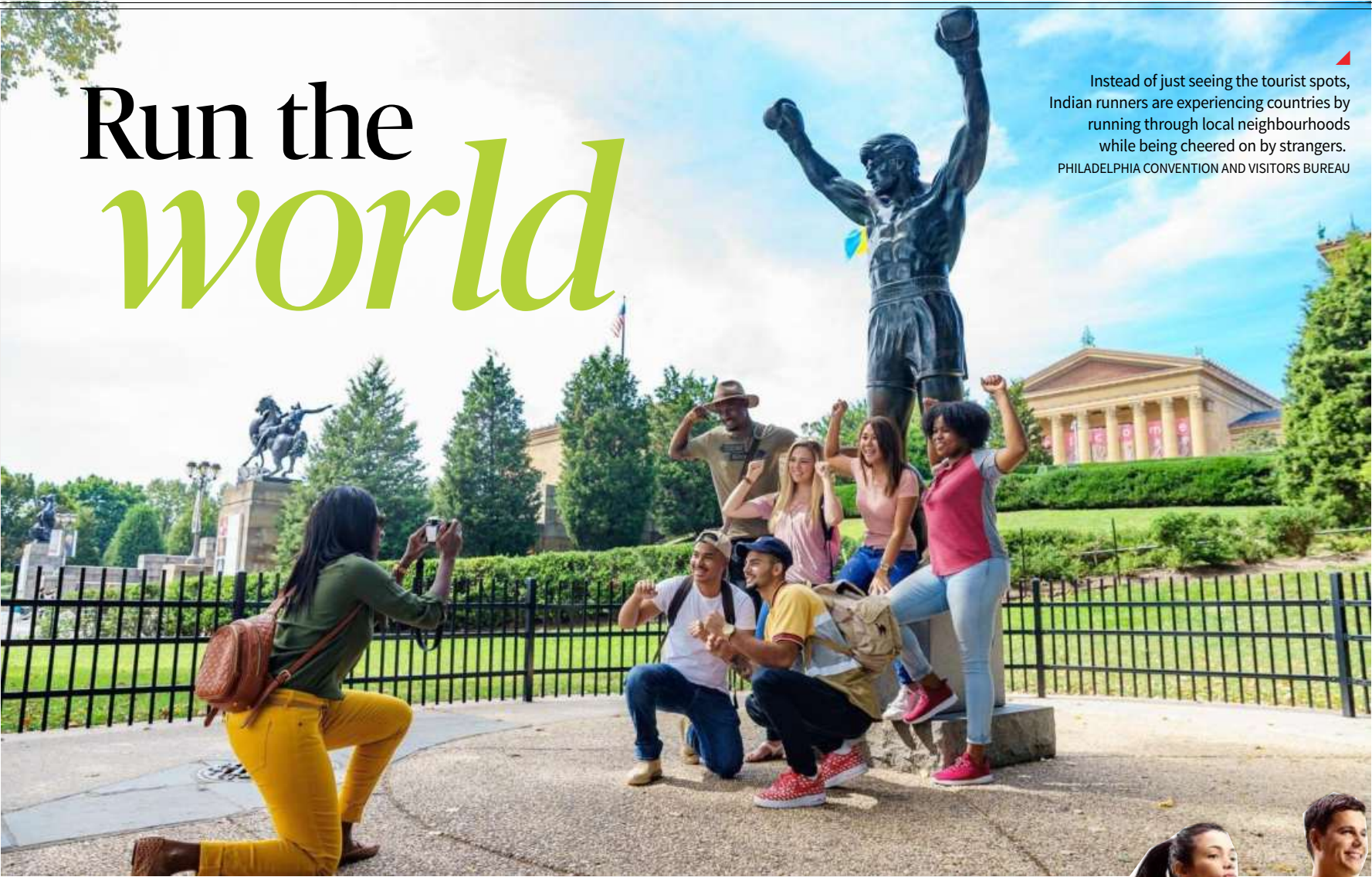
Upcoming Races

- London Marathon, April 26, 2026: One of the world's most popular races with 1.1 million applicants this year.
- Cape Town Marathon, May 24, 2026: Circuit offers the dramatic Table Mountain as the backdrop.
- Sydney Marathon, August 30, 2026: Part of the Majors circuit, covering the Harbour bridge + Opera house route.
- Philadelphia Marathon, November 22, 2026: Race coincides with 250 years of America's independence with major city-wide events.

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The industry has noticed this shift. Hotels now advertise proximity to running routes, and travel agents curate itineraries around race weekends. Airports are also getting travellers to lace up their shoes. In Hyderabad the Airport Run, held at Rajiv Gandhi International Airport every January, covers 5K and 10K, bringing first-timers and seasoned athletes together. And the annual 5K on the runway at Philadelphia International Airport offers the rare experience of racing right on a tarmac while aircraft take off and land on neighbouring runways.

In India, February offers the stripped-down community-run marathon in Auroville, and the Jaisalmer half marathon, held against sand dunes, forts and the desert festival. In June, runners go to Coorg for the Bison Ultra, set on the steep coffee estates. And if you are



Instead of just seeing the tourist spots, Indian runners are experiencing countries by running through local neighbourhoods while being cheered on by strangers. PHILADELPHIA CONVENTION AND VISITORS BUREAU

game for something even more challenging, try the Ladakh high-altitude marathon, held in Leh.

Daivik Rai, the captain of the Indian indoor cricket team ran the Philadelphia Marathon last year just so he could run in 'Rocky's footsteps' – the 72 stone steps leading to the Philadelphia Museum of Art's East entrance immortalised in cinema history by Sylvester Stallone. This year America's 250th Independence Day coincides with 50 years of Rocky, so the city is gearing up for an iconic marathon.

Post-race, many athletes walk straight to the Benjamin Franklin Parkway's green spaces for cooldowns or recovery stretching, while sports physiotherapy clinics report increased bookings

during marathon week. Several clinics offer marathon-specific recovery packages: ice baths, compression therapy and gait analysis, timed perfectly around race weekends.

The race to train

Unlike conventional vacations, race-cations come with a lot of structure. There is serious commitment involved: months of training, careful planning, balancing work schedules and budgets. Practising can begin anywhere between one and three months before the race.

Mohammed Suhail, founder of Fit District in Bengaluru, trains both amateur and professional endurance athletes. Not to mention actors like Varun Dhawan and Yash

Training Tips

- DO's**
1. Increase training mileage by up to 10% every week.
 2. Train in similar conditions locally, before attempting international circuits.
 3. Reduce training load 2-3 weeks before competition to aid recovery.
 4. For runs over 60-90 minutes, drink carbohydrate-electrolyte combinations.

- DON'Ts**
1. Don't try anything new on race day like unfamiliar gear or nutrition.
 2. Don't forget sun protection on long runs to reduce UV damage.
 3. Don't skip rest days.

— MOHAMMED SUHAIL

(born Naveen Kumar Gowda). "I ask runners to skip bar hopping and the much-coveted buffet spreads while on a running vacation," he says. "They are advised to pack their suitcases with electrolytes and protein shakes. And still, they don't find it restrictive."

While city marathons dominate the race-cation conversation, some Indian runners are taking the idea further. They are eyeing extreme environments where travel,



endurance, and survival blur into one. Ultramarathon runner Kieren D'Souza, currently based out of Manali, and known for competing in sub-zero conditions, represents this edge of the running spectrum. Racing in temperatures that can plunge to -10°C and even -15°C also means you need to acclimatise locally, by practising in places like Jammu or Kashmir.

Kieren is currently in Ladakh training for the upcoming marathon season. "In races that stretch to 100 kilometres or run over 48 hours, it's as much a mental challenge as a physical one," Kieren explains. For him, racing in foreign territories is a way to discover how far he can push himself. Of all the races so far, the Yading Skyrace in China, held at an altitude of 4000 metres was the his toughest, and most rewarding, challenge.

Kieren believes that eating right is, in fact, more challenging than the marathon itself. "It's hard to get your macros in – so I end up eating a good steak on most days, full of fresh veggies and meat. I also make sure I have a lot of fruits tucked into my bags or training kits – it's refreshing and gives me a good boost of energy."

For Sahirah, mental strength is as important as physical strength. She believes in a diet of daily meditation before taking on a new running challenge in a new country. "I believe that running outside one's comfort zone keeps one mentally agile," she says.

Kieren agrees. He reminisces about his first-ever race-cation in 2015 at the prestigious CCC Marathon in the French Alps which is a 100kilometre trail as part of the UTMB Mont Blanc festival. For him, it was a period of getting comfortable with solitude – without his family and friends cheering him on.

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Did you know West Bengal grows more than 1,500 varieties of rice? Yet, when you go to the market you only see five kinds of basmati and gobindo bhog.

“I remember growing up with chamarmani, shiddho chhal, the GI-tagged tulaipanji and so many other varieties. In the next 10 years, it’ll all be gone,” says Chef Avinandan Kundu of Cafe Sienna and Rannaghor. He adds, “As restaurants we need to be responsible about what we cook and what we put out. At Rannaghor (Bengali for kitchen) by Sienna we are keeping alive old stories and ingredients from Bengal.”

Since August 2025, the top floor of Cafe Sienna has transformed into an intimate eight-seater dining space, open three days a week, with Avinandan and Chef Koyel Nandy running the show with a team of six.

The menu here is a contrast from what the cafe below serves. While the menu in Sienna is urban-centric, in Rannaghor, recipes are inspired by childhood memories. “I remember my mom and grandmom in the kitchen, giving me a bite of mach bhaja straight from the *korai*”, says Avinandan.

District diaries

The chefs started by exploring the Bankura and Birbhum districts. In Bankura, the chefs tried ant chutney made by the Santhals (indigenous ethic groups in West Bengal, Jharkhand, Bihar, and Odisha.) “We got the ants frozen, it’ll be on the Rannaghor menu once we figure out what the vegetarian counterpart is,” smiles Avinandan, adding that in Bankura they don’t use garam masala. “The flavour comes from just onion, garlic, and chilli. We have been to two other districts where they don’t use panchphoron.”

The Sunderbans, and North Bengal, is next on their list. “People only know of momos. There is so much dairy fermentation that happens there. There is influence from Tibet and China. Dooars, Kalimpong and Jalpaiguri are also on the list. If we stop exploring and learning, all this (he points to the kitchen) will stop to exist,” he states.



Kitchen in remix mode

At Rannaghor, chefs Avinandan Kundu and Koyel Nandy are rethinking Bengali cuisine by travelling across districts and reviving lesser-known ingredients for seasonal tasting menus



The 13-course menu steers clear of Bengali staples like potato, panchphoron and kosha mangsho. MOULI PAUL

menu makes even a Bengali like me feel inadequate about my knowledge of the cuisine. The first course is pickled bittergourd served with Bandel cheese and moringa flowers. Flavours are sharp but not harsh, and the dish activates my palate. There is bacon, but it is made from the belly of a 20 kilogram catla fish. It is cured, smoked, and served with cheese made of Dhakai paneer, pineapple jelly and aalobukhara jam.

Avinandan’s favourite dish rezala finds place on the menu too. It is my favourite too, especially the deeply savoury bone marrow butter on top. Courses are paired with cocktails such as Bhaat & Bitters, fragrant with ingredients such as Radha tilak rice, mirin, rum and aromatic bitters; Kalo Jeere Martini that is heady with tequila infused with nigella seeds, vermouth, pickled fig, london dry gin; and Kalo Jeere Sour with gin and kalo jeere infused tequila.

Through the course of the meal, entrees like kopi kidney display techniques the team learned in arid Bankura. Here the dried cabbage is cooked in reduced cabbage stock with mutton kidney on top and a gel made with leaves from the cabbage’s outer layer, with

Given Bengal’s diversity, the chefs deliberately avoid familiar dishes. Since it irks them when visitors reduce Bengali food to kosha mangsho, daab chingri and aloo posto, the menu at Rannaghor steers clear of these. So they set themselves rules – there is nothing *kosha* on the menu, no panchphoron, and no (gasp!) potato.

The old-world, handwritten menu deliberately retains Bengali names for the ingredients and dishes, though it has been transliterated into English for the convenience of the diners. For example, scampi is given as galda chingri, bitter gourd as ucchey, cabbage is kopi, and fish – maach.

On the day I dine here, the 13-course



a dash of ginger. Along with that is a sauce that tastes a wee bit like chattur shorbot (a drink made with sattu and water) but here it is recreated with toasted milk powder and goat milk and has a nutty, umami, taste.

“Using dried vegetables, sea fish (Bengal mostly consumes freshwater fish), horse gram (something that’s not common in urban settings), these do not fit into Bengali stereotypes. We have locals in their 70s, who have lived here all their life but come here and discover something new,” says Avinandan.

Fuelled by nostalgia

Dessert is a nostalgic affair. There is a Horlicks caramel ice cream that takes me back to the days when I spooned the powder straight from the jar into my mouth. Mishti dokaan (sweet shop) features four sweets: their take on shor bhaja, malpua, potol mishti (made of pointed gourd) with paan leaves, and monohara.

The seats overlook the compact kitchen where the team efficiently fries, grills, slices, cuts, and plates each dish, unperturbed by curious customers and their raised cameras.

Chef Koyel stops by for a chat after service, face flushed but a big smile intact. From her passionate conversation, it is obvious that Koyel is a custodian of all things Bengali cuisine has to offer. The menu, she says will keep changing seasonally.

Dinner concludes with a welcome surprise for every Bengali obsessed with their digestion (an inevitable after-dinner discussion on acidity): Aqua Ptychotis, a concentrated solution of jowan (carom seeds). To be honest, it draws a bigger smile than even the macher muro (fish head).

As I leave with my stomach full, acidity under control, and a sense of bliss, I recall an old proverb from the region: “*Maach, maangsho, mishti – Bangalir jiboner teen tirtho*” (Fish, meat, and sweets – the three holy pilgrimages of a Bengali’s life).

The meal costs ₹4,500 including taxes for the current 13-course menu. Booking is via the District by Zomato app. For details, call 6291068080.



A flutter of painted wings

From Bengaluru’s urban forests to the Northeast’s biodiversity hotspots, enthusiasts and experts are turning butterfly-watching into a powerful gateway to ecology, education, and sustainable travel

Preeti Zachariah
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Rohit Girotra, one of the founding members of the Bangalore Butterfly Club (BBC), is enamoured by the “beautiful world” of these colourful insects. It is why he began the BBC to introduce other Bengalureans to them and has been helming butterfly walks– guided educational tools that help participants identify, learn more about or simply enjoy butterflies – in the city since 2012.

Today, the BBC community is nearly 600 strong, and it continues to grow. “I feel we have been successful in doing this,” says Rohit, who, along with another BBC co-founder, Ashok Sengupta, launched another Nature initiative, Papilio Trails, in 2025, which offers a butterfly-focussed travel experience. “The moment we announce a trip to a particular location, it gets filled in no time: within seven to 10 days,” says Rohit, adding that people are always eager to join these getaways.

Interest in butterflies and activities around them has been rising, agrees Navi Mumbai-based naturalist and photographer Isaac Kehimkar, the author of several books about butterflies, such as *The Book of Indian Butterflies* and the *BNHS Field Guide Butterflies of India*. According to him, there are over 40 active Facebook groups worldwide dedicated to these attractive insects. “Social media has done a wonderful job of raising awareness and bringing people closer to butterflies.” Additionally, with mobile cameras getting so good, “it has become so easy to upload pictures, share them with each other and get help in identifying butterflies,” he says.

Winged wonders

Butterflies and moths, found on every continent except Antarctica, exhibit a range of unique, fascinating behaviours, making them a delight to watch.

For instance, they often resort to a phenomenon called mud-puddling, in which groups of butterflies, mostly male, congregate on moist surfaces such as soil and



manure, to soak up supplementary nutrients such as salts and minerals.

Then there is Batesian mimicry, a survival strategy in which harmless butterflies, such as the Common Mormon and Painted Sawtooth, mimic toxic species, such as the Common Rose and Common Jezebel. There is also migration – sometimes even across continents and generations – the most famous being the Monarch Butterfly, which is known to travel up to 5000 kilometres to escape freezing winters in North America.

It helps that they are lovely to look at, especially on a sunny morning or late in the afternoon (the best time to watch butterflies), hovering over flowers with their varicoloured, powdery wings.

“It is a natural thing for a child to get hooked onto the colours of a butterfly,” says Ashok. His opinion is echoed by Govardhan T, the naturalist at NV Ecofarms in Goa, a sustainable tourism brand, which, among other offerings, is home to a dedicated butterfly park. “Everyone loves butterflies and connects to them,” he says.

Partha Sarathi Mondal, senior zoo biologist, at the Bhagwan Birsa

Biological Park in Ormanjhi, Ranchi, which formally inaugurated a butterfly park on its premises in 2023, says that spreading the word about these insects is important for yet another reason: “Butterflies and moths are indicators of a healthy environment and healthy ecosystems.”

Since areas rich in butterflies and moths are also likely to be rich in other invertebrates, these collectively provide a wide range of environmental benefits, including pollination and pest control. So important are these insects that, “if these three species, moths, butterflies and bees were lost, then the human population would not survive because there would be no food,” says Rohit.

Venues to visit

Over the past few years, a number of butterfly-focussed parks, trails and activities have emerged across the country, one of which is Sammilan Shetty’s Butterfly Park, located at Belvai, near Moodabidri, at the foothills of the Western Ghats.

Sammilan, a conservationist, says the park has been regularly conducting walks, workshops, and awareness programmes on its premises, focussing not just on butterflies but

(Clockwise from far left) Participants on a butterfly walk, mud-puddling butterflies, butterfly-rearing in Ormanjhi, a Blue Mormon. ISAAC KEHIMKAR, SAMMILAN SHETTY AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

also on birds, spiders, dragonflies, frogs, and mushrooms. “This is a model for people to understand how butterflies and other fauna can thrive if you conserve the natural environment,” he believes.

Isaac, who regularly conducts butterfly walks and has himself set up a butterfly garden on his private property in Tembhre, Karjat, reveals why India is such a great place for watching butterflies: it harbours an astounding diversity of the winged creatures.

“In England, you have only 47 species of butterflies, but we have over 1,300 species. You just need to make a garden, and they will come to you,” says Isaac, whose garden gets about 80 species of butterfly visitors, though the actual number varies through the year.

“In the Western Ghats, where we are located, the population of butterflies falls in summer. The best time to see them is between when the monsoon trails off and winter, mid-August and the end of December-January,” he says.

While the Western Ghats, which is home to around 330 species of butterflies, is a major butterfly hotspot, the Northeastern part of India is possibly the best region for butterfly spotting, with over half the species found in India seen there. “Bhutan, Sikkim, Assam, Nagaland, Mizoram, and Arunachal Pradesh are amazing,” confirms Isaac, who has ended up travelling widely across the country in his search for more butterflies. He adds, “I discovered India in that process. Butterflies showed me

how beautiful our country truly is.”



Tamil

Promising mission undone by excess



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There's intrigue the minute *Mr X* opens on the big screen. Did you know that in 1965, India and the United States of America joined hands for an operation that attempted to install a nuclear-powered surveillance device on the Nanda Devi mountain range, the aim being able to monitor Chinese missile and nuclear activity?

Mr X throws open this sequence at first, and immediately cuts to Chennai, where we spot a shirtless Goutham (Arya) emerging from an underwater fitness routine. Goutham is a secret RAW agent, as are the other members of his team. On the surface, they are just ordinary people, like a businessman and a delivery driver. But when there's a mission, they should unite.

As they do, busting a money laundering racket in Sowcarpet with all guns blazing. So, is Goutham Mr X? What is the connection between him and the missing missile from the Nanda Devi operation?

For answers, you will have to sit through 153 minutes involving multiple characters who have multiple backstories, long-drawn action sequences that do not seem to end and twists that are not entirely necessary.

The makers intend to design it as a slick, Hollywood-style spy thriller but halfway, it becomes not just predictable but also too long-winding for its own good.

Director Manu Anand's film begins with an announcement stating that it is a "fictional story, woven together by various incidents that reportedly happened over a period of time", and that long passage of time *shows*. The characters are in Chennai at one instance, and suddenly, they are in Russia, even as a flashback shows a sequence in Pakistan.

In terms of physicality, Arya fits the bill of a RAW agent. But there's little scope for performance for the actor in him,...which is why even in a supposedly emotional scene, he stays cold.

Amaran (Gautham Karthik) is written much better. With a code name that goes 'Lone Wolf', the actor's deceiving smile hides something far more grey than he reveals. If used well, Gautham Karthik might well turn out to be a good choice for future Tamil filmmakers scouting for actors to play young, sophisticated villains. And then there's Sarath Kumar, who has a crucial character in the scheme of things. While he aces the routine action sequences, he also appears in a throwback of sorts to a few popular characters he has played in the past, which brings a smile. Manju Warrier has an impact in a role that could have probably been developed better.

Crisp editing by Prasanna GK and music by Dhibu Ninan Thomas cannot salvage the largely forgettable second half that even features a sequence *after* what we perceive to be the end, thus setting the stage for a *Mr X 2*. Now, that is not a mission we are looking forward to undertake.

Mr X is currently running in theatres



A dose of supernatural chaos

Akshay Kumar and Priyadarshan stretch hard to rediscover their old mojo in a painfully formulaic horror-comedy that feels more like a tired tribute

Hindi

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Built between fear and farce, *Bhooth Bangla* seeks to rekindle the magic that Priyadarshan and Akshay Kumar created in *Bhool Bhulaiyaa* before Anees Bazmee and Kartik Aaryan took the franchise forward with two spiritual successors. As the OGs of situational comedy lay claim to humor in the haunted mansion, we discover that originality has long been lost in its cobwebs. The result is a forced trip down nostalgia lane, packaged as a summer holiday entertainer, where a few wisecracks, a couple of jump scares manage to seep through the ceiling, but even they feel like leaks from outdated plumbing after a point.

When Arjun Acharya (Akshay), the son of a theologian (Jishu Sengupta), inherits his grandfather's grand yet eerie ancestral palace in rural Mangalpur, he sees it as an opportunity to pay off his debt and plan his sister's wedding there. Forced by circumstances, Arjun brushes off local warnings about a curse and a ghost that

Bhooth Bangla

Director: Priyadarshan

Cast: Akshay Kumar, Tabu, Wamiqa Gabbi, Mithila Palkar, Paresch Rawal, Asrani, Rajpal Yadav, Jisshu Sengupta, Rajesh Sharma

Synopsis: When Arjun Acharya inherits his grandfather's grand but notoriously haunted ancestral palace and decides to host his sister's wedding there, ignoring local warnings about a deadly curse, strange supernatural events unfold.



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targets brides. Supernatural chaos ensues, forcing him to confront the mansion's dark history involving black magic, mythology-inspired legends, and unresolved betrayals.

The screenplay (Rohan Shankar and Abilash Nair) is distinctly bifurcated. It comes as a surprise that in a Priyadarshan film, the first half suffers from a glaring lack of coherence, with gags feeling loosely strung together rather than building into a cohesive comedic crescendo. The second half, on the other hand, shifts into an emotional mystery that adds weight, evokes interest, but struggles to escape the patina of predictability.

Akshay, for all his undeniable energy, largely repeats himself – delivering the same brand of wide-eyed exasperation, physical comedy, and heroic sincerity we've seen him perfect over the last two decades. There are several scenes where you can visibly feel Akshay stretching himself thin, desperately trying to inject life into jokes that are mere echoes of the past.

A barrage of sexist and toilet-bound gags try hard to land, but end up leaving a foul aftertaste. Even as Paresch Rawal and late Asrani (in perhaps his last big screen performance) valiantly attempt to summon situational humour, the laughs

arrive with visible effort, like ghosts struggling to materialise. The carelessness in writing is evident, as the dialogue writer confuses dakshina (an offering to a priest) with bakshish (a tip). Amidst the chaos, Rajpal Yadav retains his flair for buffoonery, delivering the kind of manic energy that still elicits chuckles even as the script creaks around him.

The women drift through the haunted mansion like elegant but empty portraits. Tabu, Wamiqa Gabbi, and Mithila Palkar are given minimal scope, mostly to scream or react, while the men command the chaos.

The special effects and cinematography are among the film's stronger assets, but they remain functional rather than groundbreaking. While Pritam is usually reliable, the music and background score here feel safe, dated, and uninspired.

In the end, *Bhooth Bangla* leaves one with a feeling that some memories and mansions are better left abandoned. For all its chaotic charm and Akshay's visible effort, it turns out to be a formulaic entertainer that delivers fleeting laughs but leaves you wondering why they bothered reopening the Bangla at all.

Bhooth Bangla is currently running in theatres

Tovino Thomas' latest is a period drama that fails to take off

Malayalam

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Subtlety has never been one of filmmaker Dijo Jose Antony's core strengths, but even by his standards, the choices he makes in his fourth film, *Pallichattambi*, are quite odd. Like, the idea to introduce a much-feared antagonist by having him kill his pet dog with a fork, just because it was barking a little too much. The act was also to send a message to two men who walked in with unfavourable information during his dinnertime.

The film's treatment of history also follows a similar pattern, of landing a sharp fork at pages of history. Set amid the tumultuous period of the Vimochana Samaram (Liberation Struggle), led by revanchist forces against the land and educational reforms brought in by Kerala's first Communist government in the late 1950s, the film's protagonist is Pothan (Tovino



Thomas), a strongman chosen by the Church to lead the 'Christopher Sena' to resist the Communists.

However, the filmmaker, without taking a stand on either side, brings in a fictional external enemy, a powerful feudal lord from outside the State, and lays all the blame for the violence and bloodshed at his

feet. It is par for the course for a historical fiction to take such liberties with the truth. But in the current context, people tend to have a skewed understanding of historical events thanks to such interpretations. Filmmaker TV. Chandran has, in the past, depicted Vimochana Samaram in a more

historically accurate manner in films such as *Ormakal Undayirikkanam* and *Dany*, portraying it as a counter-revolution of the privileged classes against emancipatory policies.

As if to make up for its treatment of history, *Pallichattambi* opts for a very dated approach in writing and

filmmaking. Dijo Jose's loud treatment in his previous films, such as *Jana Gana Mana* and *Malayalee From India*, is repeated here. Although Suresh Babu has scripted *Pallichattambi*, instead of Dijo's usual screenwriter, Sharis Mohammed, not much difference in approach is visible, indicating the significant writing role of the filmmaker. The exposition is so complete. It covers even the minor details, leaving no

room for interpretation or reflection. The heavy-handed approach is apparent in Pothan's budding romance with KPAC Rebecca (Kayadu Lohar).

The cameo by a major star also fails to elevate the movie. In fact, most of the characters and their relationship with each other are weakly established, so much so that even the most shocking events fail to make an impact.

Tovino Thomas brings an admirable physicality to the role, but the weak screenplay doesn't allow him to do anything more. The period setting is inconsistent. The hint dropped at the climax regarding a sequel, without entirely resolving the narrative conflict in this part, becomes another dampener. The director follows the easy decision chosen by many filmmakers and screenwriters these days, with the sequel never materialising. *Pallichattambi* is an ahistorical period movie that fails to takes off.

Pallichattambi is currently running in theatres



Normal

Director: Ben Wheatley

Cast: Bob Odenkirk, Lena Headey, Henry Winkler, Billy MacLellan

Storyline: A substitute Sheriff get stuck in a quagmire when he unearths a dark secret about a small town in Minnesota

A darkly comic small-town shootout

English

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Derek Kolstad. Bob Odenkirk. Guns. Dynamites. An everyday man in a quaint American town. I am sold. After their popular collaboration in the slick streak films *Nobody* and *Nobody 2*, *John Wick's* Kolstad once again drops Odenkirk 2.0 as a normal guy in a small town where everything is trigger-wired for

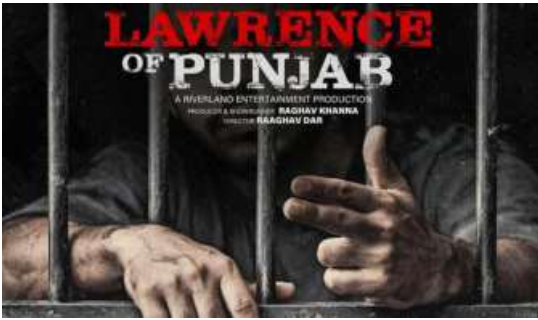
cinematic mayhem. *Normal*, which has a story written by Kolstad and Odenkirk, is a blood-slick popcorn actioner that offers the gleeful satisfaction of watching those brainrot puzzle videos on YouTube. Everything happens as you expect, and everything feels delightfully *normal*. It is winter in Normal, Minnesota, where Odenkirk's Ulysses is sent to as an interim Sheriff due to the untimely demise of the town's reputed Sheriff, Gunderson. Coming from a personal tragedy himself, Ulysses hopes for some quiet and healing in these mundane, icy scapes. What captures you instantly is the specific atmosphere. Normal is not just a fictional snow-covered town ironically named, it is a town where nothing is as it seems, and everything is normal, in a twisted way sort of way. There are certainly quite a few giveaways, which Ulysses does observe – they have somehow raised \$16 million for their town hall, the Sheriff station has an excessively disproportionate armoury, Gunderson's death

seems urgently brushed under the carpet, and even the friendly-neighbourhood-elderly-Asian-woman surveils police activity through a scanner. Gunderson's funeral is where Ulysses' cop-senses tingle; however, like with every other sign, he brushes them off and gives in to the appeal of the small town. But of course, the guns in the diner aren't for decorations, of course, the Asian lady isn't who she says she is, and of course, the C4 in the armoury isn't just a passing detail. *Normal* pulls the pin when two ragtag bank robbers, Lori (Reena Jolly) and Keith (Brendan Fletcher), attempt a heist at the Normal Bank. Ulysses and his troops, consisting of Deputy Mike Nelson (Billy MacLellan) and Deputy Blaine Anderson (Ryan Allen), arrive at the scene. All hell breaks loose. There's hardly a moment when *Normal* takes itself seriously. Every action set piece revels in a hilariously grisly and macabre sense of cinematic violence. The staging feels contrived, sure, but the escalating stakes keep you hooked. A metal signboard dropping on a man is a generic

idea, yes, but also somehow very funny. It's the close-quarter action that makes you lean forward more than the pyrotechnics; punches are inches away, explosions happen merely feet away. A sequence in the diner with an automatic vinyl turntable makes for such a pleasurable song-and-fight sequence, and watching Odenkirk kick butt with knives, dynamites, pistols, and a grenade launcher is a new normal we are pleased to be in. Surprisingly, *Normal* allows the actor to lean more towards his comedic stance than the *Nobody* films – the only major difference is that Wheatley's film alludes to a deeper character portrait for Odenkirk, though the writing doesn't really take that detail anywhere novel. The film does suffer a few bullet holes to its plot. The prologue showing the Yakuza dilutes surprises, and the way it all wraps up feels eerily ironed out. But "life's a lot easier when you care a little less."

Normal is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Lawrence of Punjab: ZEE5's upcoming docu-series sets premiere date

An upcoming docu-series, *Lawrence of Punjab*, will be released on ZEE5 on April 27, the streamer announced on April 19. Directed by Raghav Darr, the show "traces the journey of a criminal identity through the lens of culture, systems, and visibility". The makers said in a press release that the series looks at gangster Lawrence Bishnoi as a case study within the ecosystem of student politics, music, ideology and media amplification. "The narrative expands beyond the individual to examine the larger cultural and social context, focusing on consequences," read the press note. Speaking about the show, Raghav said, "*Lawrence of Punjab* was always envisioned as more than a crime story."



Vijay Deverakonda to work with Shouryuv of Hi Nanna fame

Telugu star Vijay Deverakonda has joined hands with director Shouryuv of *Hi Naana* fame for his next. The movie will be produced by Vyra Entertainments. The project, tentatively called *VDxShouryuv*, will have music from Hesham Abdul Wahab. Deverakonda released an intriguing poster to announce the film. The poster introduces the crew members of the movie in a unique manner. Deverakonda is seen holding chains attached to black dogs that walk ahead of him. Alejandro Martinez is the cinematographer while Praveen Antony is the editor. Sachin Lovalekar will handle the costumes. Suresh Selvarajan is the production designer.



Actor-director Jojo George announces his second directorial venture

Popular Malayalam actor-director Jojo George unveiled his second directorial project titled *Paripadi* recently. Jojo shared the title poster of the film on social media with the tagline, "Never mistake silence". *Paripadi*, produced by Venu Kunnappilly under the banner of Kavya Film Company, marks Jojo's return as a director after the action-thriller *Pani*, which garnered box-office success and critical praise. In May 2025, he had announced a sequel to the film, with a plan to make it a three-part franchise. *Paripadi*, also penned by Jojo, has already gained hype thanks to ace Tamil music director Yuvan Shankar Raja.



Too many cooks, not enough meat

Lee Sung Jin's sharp, simmering class feud has swelled into a crowded, overworked spread that loses the very bite that made *Beef* worth chewing on in the first place

English

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The first season of *Beef* had the good sense to stay small and mean. A botched parking lot encounter between Ali Wong and Steven Yeun kept feeding on itself until it spiralled towards mythic proportions, but it never lost sight of the mundane humiliations that powered it – every act of revenge felt like a miscalculation that still made emotional sense in the moment. Showrunner Lee Sung Jin crafted a series of intricate, escalating chain reactions, with each successful ragebait by the other tightening the screw until the final stretch hit with a beautiful, exhausted kind of clarity. Season 2, produced again for Netflix with A24 backing and directed in part by returning collaborators like Jake Schreier, expands that intimate design into something broader and more unwieldy, shifting from a two-character spiral into an ensemble anchored by two couples whose lives intersect at a Southern California country club. Oscar Isaac plays Josh Martin, a general manager whose job depends on maintaining the illusion of effortless luxury for clients who pay initiation fees that dwarf his own savings, while Carey Mulligan plays Lindsay, his British wife who drifts between interior design gigs and social hosting while mourning the erosion of a more privileged past. Their counterparts are Austin, a part-time personal trainer played by Charles Melton, and Ashley, a beverage cart worker played by Cailee Spaeny, whose financial precarity is established early through scenes of absent benefits and a looming medical diagnosis that requires insurance she does not have. The inciting incident this season mirrors the structural logic of the first, as Austin and Ashley arrive at Josh and Lindsay's home to return a forgotten wallet and instead witness a marital argument that escalates into physical violence, which Ashley instinctively records on her phone. This video

Beef Season 2

Creator: Lee Sung Jin

Cast: Oscar Isaac, Carey Mulligan, Cailee Spaeny, Charles Melton, Youn Yuh-jung, Song Kang-hoSeoyeon Jang

Episodes: 8

Storyline: A high-stakes feud ignites after the lower-level staff members witness a toxic fight between their boss and his wife at an exclusive country club

becomes the currency that binds the two couples, leading Ashley to demand a promotion that would grant her health coverage, while Josh attempts to contain the damage through intimidation that only accelerates the conflict. This sets off a chain of retaliation involving workplace manipulation, financial deceit, and increasingly desperate attempts to maintain control over situations that have already slipped beyond it. Josh is a study in managed desperation. His arc is defined by performance fatigue, visible in sequences where he constructs what he calls "a land of make believe" for club members while accumulating personal debt and emotional exhaustion, and Isaac locates that strain in small gestures, including the way Josh's practiced smile collapses once he is alone or the clipped defensiveness that emerges when Lindsay reminds him of their financial reality. Lindsay operates on a different frequency. Mulligan shapes her resentment into cutting observations about their stalled ambitions, particularly their long-delayed plan to open a boutique bed-and-breakfast that exists more as a shared illusion than a viable future, and her dissatisfaction surfaces as she performs social grace while cataloguing every slight in real time. Austin and Ashley are written with a deliberate tension between satire and sympathy, as the series frames them through moments that meander between naivety and opportunism, including Austin's attempt to process relationship anxiety by searching "fiancé weird sex why" on Reddit, or his tendency to recite half-understood Marxist rhetoric during moments that demand practical action; all of which positions him at the edge of satire while still grounding him in a recognisable form of drift. Ashley, by contrast, exhibits sharper instincts, especially in the scenes where she recalibrates her approach to Josh after his threats, shifting from hesitation to calculated aggression. Yet her motivations remain rooted in tangible fears about healthcare access, and her fiancé smitten by an attractive Korean workplace rival, which lends her actions a clarity that the show occasionally undermines through contrived escalations.

The expanded cast introduces a third axis of power through Youn Yuh-jung as Chairwoman Park, the billionaire owner of the country club, who reframes every existing conflict as subordinate to capital. Her scenes are defined by a calm indifference, whether she is assessing renovation plans or discussing how to bail her husband out of medical malpractice. Song Kang-ho appears as Dr Kim, whose trembling hands have killed a patient and whose storyline unfolds largely in Seoul before intersecting with the main narrative in the finale. And Seoyeon Jang, as Eunice, functions as both assistant and intermediary, but her presence becomes most charged in scenes where Ashley perceives her as a decided threat to her married life. The season's thematic ambitions are articulated through recurring situations, including a hellish hospital episode where Ashley navigates insurance barriers that reduce her potentially fatal ovarian cyst to administrative categories, and a sequence involving the search for Lindsay's dachshund, *Burberry*, which exposes how disproportionate attention is allocated based on class position. Generational tension is also embedded in behaviour, as Austin and Ashley approach their future through optimism that has not yet been tested, while Josh and Lindsay operate within the residue of failed expectations; the show repeatedly contrasts these states through parallel scenes of intimacy that reveal how financial anxiety reshapes emotional expression. This sprawl of scattered ambition becomes this season's defining problem. The brilliant first season moved with purpose because every action fed back into that central brawl, tightening the loop until it snapped. But this second over-seasoned and underdone helping of *Beef* keeps opening new loops and then struggles to close them, which inevitably forgets what made the meat tender. There are sharp scenes throughout, and the cast does careful work within them, though the writing never quite recaptures the brutal simplicity that made the first one feel so delicious.

Beef Season 2 is currently streaming on Netflix